RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO THE MISHNAH

Who Was the World Made For? Sages and the People of the Land

Rambam's Intro to the Mishnah, Part 8

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to the Commentary on the Mishnah (Rav Shilat's edition), section ז: why Hashem created so many who never pursue wisdom

Shiur: Part 8 (penultimate) of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 8 July 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

Over seven classes: the Oral Torah; Sages vs prophets; the purpose, structure and order of the **Mishnah**; the **Talmud's** four purposes, the fourth being ***derashot***, which led the Rambam to the puzzling statement:

אין לו להקב״ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה בלבד.

What can it mean? There **was no halachah** in the days of **Shem and Ever's yeshivah**, or Avraham. So the Rambam digressed into **the purpose of Earth** (not the whole universe): man-made things have obvious purposes; natural things serve **the human**, broadly speaking, and the wiser you are, the more of their purposes you grasp. **The human's purpose:** to fully develop **intellect** (all disciplines, culminating in knowing **Hashem**) and **character**. A person isn't complete without **both**.

The Question

You said Divine wisdom makes nothing in vain; the most honoured creature on earth is man; man's purpose is the intellect. **Then why did Hashem create all the people who never develop it?** **ונשארה כאן שאלה אחת.**

most people are **naked of wisdom**, chasing pleasures. **The wise, restrained person is a rarity, a marvel** one in many generations. **ואנחנו נמצא שרוב בני האדם ערומים מן החכמה, מבקשי תאוות: לא ימצא אלא אחד בדור מן הדורות,**

Clarifying the question

It isn't a question about people. Each person has **בחירה**, free will, which the Rambam calls **an עמוד גדול**, a great pillar of the Torah. That few choose this path is **the person's** problem.

It's a question about Hashem. If He made the Earth for **the perfected human**, and that person comes along once in generations, "**statistically, it doesn't seem to make sense.**"

Answer 1: The Others Make the Sage's Life Possible

מציאות כל אותם בני אדם לשתי סיבות. האחת, לשמש לאיש ההוא.

Their existence has two reasons. **First, to serve that one person.**

The Rambam is **"very pragmatic"**:

> **שאילו היו בני אדם כולם מבקשי החכמה ומתפלספים, היה העולם חרב והיה נכרת המין האנושי בזמן מועט.**

If everyone were a philosopher, the world would stop, and humanity wouldn't last long.

Why? Humans are **deeply needy**:

To have...	You'd need to learn...
Bread	Ploughing, harvesting, threshing, grinding, cooking, baking, and making the tools
Clothes	Spinning and weaving
Shelter	Building, and all its tools

Not even **Metushelach's 969 years** would be enough **ולא יספיקו ימי מתושלח ללמוד אלו המלאכות.** to learn them all. And when would you study?

So Hashem created everyone else to do that work: **תתיישב הארץ ותמצא החכמה**: the land is settled, **and** wisdom is found.

"If not for the madmen..."

A saying of the Rambam's time: **לולא המשוגעים היתה הארץ נחרבת**: *if not for the madmen, the world would be destroyed.*

A man, perhaps **not even strong**, **crosses the seas in winter** and **deserts in the summer heat**, exposed to **wild animals and creatures**, **for perhaps a dinar**. Then he hands his hard-won money to builders to lay deep foundations and raise **a wall to stand for centuries**, **knowing full well** he hasn't enough life left to wear out **a wall of reeds**. **"What greater folly could there be?"**

"Still true today, with different challenges: leaving your family, **planes**, exposure to illness, **Zoom meetings**, back and forth. To make money to build a mansion that will last a few hundred years, **which you'll never enjoy for a few hundred years.** In the grand scheme, it's ridiculous. **But we need it.** We need people to develop the land."

On a "learn-only" society

"It always bothered me: in some circles, **every boy** must go to yeshivah and **kollel** and **learn his whole life**, unless there are extenuating circumstances. **And then their *chachamim*, when ill, go to doctors; when they need legal advice, go to lawyers.** If everyone did what the rosh yeshivah said and studied all their lives, **where would the doctors, lawyers and builders come from?** You'd use the secular Jew, the one who only learns in the evening."

"**Long-term immersion in Torah and wisdom is amazing**, literally the pinnacle of creation. **But that's for a limited few. We need ordinary people to develop the world.**"

What *am ha'aretz* really means

ועל כן קוראים החכמים לאנשים אשר אין להם חכמה "עם הארץ", כלומר שהם עומדים לישוב הארץ.

"How beautiful." *Am ha'aretz* isn't simply "an ignoramus"; it means **"people of the land"**, those whose role is **to settle and develop the earth**: building, clothing, food. "**It's not a derogatory term.** They're a necessary part of creation."

When should everyone study? In the days of Mashiach, when everything will be provided. "From where we stand today it starts to make sense: **robots** are already taking humans' place in so many things."

Dov and Richard: is it all or nothing?

Isn't there a spectrum? Thousands are learned and fine people, not one-in-a-generation, but surely not just "general people"?

"**100%.** The Rambam talks in **extremities**. It's **not a zero-sum game**, as if you're either perfect or an *am ha'aretz*. There are millions of levels: 10%, 50%, 70%. **From the person's side**, each develops by his free choice, and dedicating yourself to study is wonderful. **From Hashem's side**, if the near-perfect person appears once in generations, why create everyone else? **Because some must be devoted to other things, to provide.**"

When the fool is served by the wise

ושמא יאמר אומר: sometimes **a foolish man**, rich through inheritance or luck, lives grandly, and **wise men work for him**. Isn't that backwards?

"You don't see the whole picture." In his wealth and power he commands a **great palace** or a **vast vineyard**, "like kings do."

One day a *chasid* will rest in that palace's shade and take delight in it, setting his mind right. **One day he'll find in that vineyard a remedy that saves him from a snakebite. כך הן הנהגות השם יתברך ויתרומם בחכמתו: עצות מרחוק אמונה אומן.**

Rav Kook in England was so taken with **Rembrandt's paintings** that he said (in words to the effect) the painter must have had **a spark of prophecy**.

Ben Zoma on the Temple Mount

בן זומא ראה אוכלוסין על גב מעלה בהר הבית, אמר: ברוך... שברא כל אלו לשמשני (Berachot 58a)

Seeing the throngs of pilgrims: *Blessed is He who created all these to serve me.*

"You hear that and think: **arrogant, narcissistic.**" **The Rambam:** he was **unique in his generation**, and his meaning is **gratitude**: *thank Hashem for a diverse humanity, people building homes, making clothes, growing food, so that I can devote myself to wisdom and character.*

What "serving the Sage" doesn't mean

"To be abundantly clear: the Rambam **strictly forbids** a *chacham* using Torah as **a spade to dig with**. **He'd have hated** the idea of simply supporting him." It means the world **develops the things** the Sage can then **acquire and use properly**. The legitimate links the Gemara allows: **doing business** with the Sage, or **marrying one's daughter** to him.

The Rambam on Bava Kamma

A law **"anti-Semites like to quote"**: if a Jew's ox gores a gentile's, in a place with **no set laws**, there's no liability. The Rambam's own **Commentary** there:

If their law favours them, we judge by their law. But where a society lacks **שלמות המדות האנושיות**, **the laws and norms between person and person that sustain human society**, its members **אינו בכלל האדם על האמת**: are not *adam* in the true sense. "This needs a discourse of its own."

The Rabbi's reading: consistent with tonight's theme, **a full *adam is one working on intellect and character. A society living without the basic values (the seven Noahide laws, courts and justice) has left the category of adam***.

Answer 2: Even the Sage Needs Company

People of real wisdom are **very few**, and that's simply how reality **.אנשי החכמה הם מעטים מאוד** is.

Don't ask why. The Rambam uses this logic often: it's like asking why there are **nine spheres** or **four elements** (fire, air, water, earth, as they believed then). In the **Moreh**: *why is the sky blue?* "If it were green, you'd ask why green."

Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai: ראיתי בני עלייה והן מועטין, אם שנים הן, אני ובני הן: *I've seen the people of ascent, and they are few; if there are two, they are my son and I.*

משום כך הומצאו ההמון להיות לחברה לאנשי המעלה.

The masses were created to be company for the people of excellence.

You may think this a small benefit. **On the contrary, it matters.** "Perhaps even more than the first .**ואולי תחשוב שזאת התועלת מעוטה? אדרבה, חשובה היא**"

His proofs:

- **Mishpatim: לא אגרשנו מפניך בשנה אחת, פן תהיה הארץ שממה**. Hashem wouldn't drive out the nations of Canaan all at once, **lest the land become desolate**.

- **Kohelet: סוף דבר הכל נשמע, את האלהים ירא ואת מצותיו שמור, כי זה כל האדם**. The Midrash: **the whole world was created only to be company for this one.**

A rabbi's memoir. "A famous American rabbi's community said at his retirement: *how will we cope without you?* He answered: ***more than you need me, I need you.*** **A rabbi without a community isn't a rabbi.** He can't give, can't influence, can't fulfil his potential."

Answer	Kind
1. To provide	**Pragmatic and physical**
2. To be company	**Emotional and social**: a life without people is **desolate and lonely**

Robert: *wouldn't a Sage rather have a few more Sages as friends?*

"Of course. But **that's not reality**: like the blue sky. **A person will take any company over loneliness.** Trust me, a rav would rather preach to an ignorant community that at least listens

than have **no one on Shabbat morning**. **More than a rabbi gives his community, the community gives the rabbi.**"

"The Four Cubits of Halachah," Solved

הלכה comes from **הליכה**, **developing**: walking with Hashem, **walking**.

ילכו מחיל אל חיל; צדיקים אין להם מנוחה: always walking, always developing.

אין לו להקב"ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה: all Hashem has in His world are **those who walk**, who keep developing their intellect and character. **That is the purpose of creation.**

"**I can't tell you how many people have asked me: *why are you still studying? You've studied so many years, take a break!*** That's not how we think. **We never stop studying until the day we die.** Every day: what more can I learn, revise, study? **There's no end.**"

וכבר התבאר... כי תכלית כל מה שבעולם ההויה וההפסד איש שלם, כולל החכמה והמעשה.

The purpose of everything in this world of coming-to-be and passing-away is the complete person, who unites wisdom and deed.

וכבר יצאנו מענין זה, אשר נכנסנו בו מרוב אהבה: *I've strayed from the topic, out of great love.* **But these are fine matters of faith, not to be taken lightly.** "Now he comes back to the Talmud."

Questions

"Isn't a great Sage's soul a gift from God, not something he develops?"

"**No, absolutely not.** That's completely **antithetical** to the Rambam's philosophy. You're thinking of something **kabbalistic**, Chassidic stories of a holy neshamah coming down. **A person must choose this path.** We're **all born with deficiencies**, and we grow." *So anyone can become like Moshe Rabbeinu?* "The Rambam writes it **black and white**, in the Mishneh Torah (Hilchot Teshuvah, ch. 5): **every person can become like Moshe Rabbeinu.**"

Richard: so is everyone else's purpose to *support* the perfect person, or to *become* perfect, and are they failing?

"A **fantastic question**; it shows real depth. **It depends on whose perspective.**

- **From the person's:** your purpose is to aim for perfection. I wouldn't say *failed*, too harsh; you haven't **maximised your potential**. **None of us has**; we all know our failings.

- **From Hashem's:** He knows only one in a generation will reach it, and **creates everyone anyway**, because of **what they provide** for that person."

Summary

1. **The question is on Hashem, not man:** man has free will; but why create a world for the perfected person who comes once in generations?
2. **Answer 1: to provide.** If all were philosophers, the world would collapse; **not even Metushelach** could master every craft. **"If not for the madmen..." Am ha'aretz = "people**

of the land," who settle it; not a slur. Not everyone should learn all day: **who'd be the doctors?** Everyone studies **in Mashiach's days**.

3. **Even the fool served by the wise** ultimately serves the wise: the **palace a chasid will rest in**, the vineyard's **cure**. **Ben Zoma's blessing** is gratitude, not arrogance.
4. **Answer 2: company.** The wise are few (**"my son and I"**), as fixed as the four elements; **the masses exist to be their society**: **פן תהיה הארץ שממה; כי זה כל האדם**. **"More than you need me, I need you."**
5. **"The four cubits of halachah"** = those who **walk**, who never stop growing. **That** is all Hashem has in His world.
6. **Greatness is chosen, not gifted**; **anyone can be like Moshe**. We all fall short of our potential, yet **everyone has a purpose**.

Coming Up

Next week (the final class), or the week after: more principles of Talmud; the Rambam's teachers, **the Rif** and **Rabbi Yosef ibn Migash**; why his Commentary on the Mishnah is so foundational; and then something "**remarkable, before ChatGPT, before encyclopedias**": **ten short chapters listing the Sages of the Mishnah, their relationships, and how often each appears.**

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/GClVsQhLnlo · More shiurim: rabbikada.com